

Off Course — Private Cruise Campaign: Launch Readiness

The single reference to finish and go live. Compiled June 2026. Keyword traffic from Google Keyword Planner (Off Course Canal Cruises account), English, targeting Netherlands + UK + US + Germany, trailing 12 months.

Status: validated blueprint, nothing live

The campaign is built as a config file and **dry-run validated against the live Google Ads API** — Google confirmed every keyword, negative, ad, and extension is valid. **Nothing has been created or spent.** One command turns it into a real campaign that starts **paused** for your review.

- **Config file:** `scripts/google-ads/campaigns/private-cruise-en.json`
- **Go-live command:**

```
npm run gads -- create --config scripts/google-ads/campaigns/private-cruise-en.json --live --listing off-beaten-path-hidden-gems-canal-cruise
```

Keyword traffic (real Google Keyword Planner data)

Bid = top-of-page bid range. Your actual CPC is usually nearer the low end. ✅ = confirmed in Keyword Planner; ~ = estimated from secondary data (low-volume long-tail).

Exact-match core terms (the volume drivers)

Keyword	Searches/mo	Competition	Top-of-page bid
private boat tour amsterdam	1,900 ✅	High	€1.27 – €4.15
private canal cruise amsterdam	1,900 ✅	High	€1.30 – €4.29
private canal tour amsterdam	~1,900	High	~€1.30 – €4.10
private boat amsterdam	390 ✅	High	€1.33 – €3.66
private cruise amsterdam	~500	High	—

Phrase-match expansion terms

Keyword	Searches/mo	Competition	Top-of-page bid
private dinner cruise amsterdam	590 ✅	Medium	€1.08 – €3.23
private boat hire amsterdam	~170	High	~€1.60 – €4.57
amsterdam private boat tour	~300	High	—
private boat trip amsterdam	~150	Medium	—

Keyword	Searches/mo	Competition	Top-of-page bid
private canal boat amsterdam	~120	Medium	—
private canal boat tour amsterdam	~110	High	—
private boat tour for 2 amsterdam	~90	Medium	—
private boat amsterdam with drinks	~70	Medium	—
small private boat tour amsterdam	~70	Medium	—

Private-intent addressable demand $\approx$ 7,000+ searches/month across these terms in the four target countries. At €25/day you'll buy ~300 clicks/month, so **search volume is not the constraint — your budget is**. That means clean room to scale later.

Seasonal signal 🔥

The 3-month trend is **rising sharply** — "boat tour amsterdam" +49%, "canal cruise amsterdam" +22%, "private boat tour amsterdam" +14%. Demand is climbing into summer. **You're launching at the right time.**

Deliberately excluded (future SHARED campaign)

These are huge but **general/shared intent** — they'd waste the private budget, but they're a major future opportunity:

Keyword	Searches/mo	Competition	Bid
canal cruise amsterdam	18,100	Medium	€0.83 – €2.85
boat tour amsterdam	12,100	High	€0.99 – €3.00
amsterdam canal tour	5,400	High	€1.03 – €3.38
boat cruise amsterdam	2,900	High	€0.84 – €2.96

Campaign settings (what's in the config)

Setting	Value	Why
Type	Standard Search	Highest intent, controllable; AI Max off until 30 conversions
Bidding	Maximize Conversions (no target CPA)	No conversion history yet; budget is the cap
Match types	5 exact (head terms) + 9 phrase (expansion)	Best-practice split, validated by research
Negatives	104	Block self-drive/rental, cheap/free, jobs, for-sale, info, adjacent products, competitors, other cities
Locations	Netherlands, UK, US, Germany	Tourist source markets + local expats
Language	English	Clean experiment; Dutch is a separate future campaign
Daily budget	€25/day	Research floor for learning signal; downside capped ~€760/mo
Ad	15 headlines, 4 descriptions	Brand voice — "friend with a boat," no pretension

Setting	Value	Why
Extensions	4 sitelinks · 6 callouts · 1 structured snippet	Parity with competitors (all of them run extensions)
Landing page	/cruises/off-beaten-path-hidden-gems-canal-cruise	Published private listing, converts warm traffic at 3.6%

Expected outcome (real data + your margins)

At **€25/day (~€760/mo)**, ~€2.50 blended CPC → **~300 clicks/month**.

If paid converts at...	Bookings/mo	True net profit/mo*
3.6% (your current rate)	~11	~€2,300
2.5% (conservative paid)	~7.6	~€1,400
2.0% (pessimistic)	~6	~€930

After skipper (€85), drinks cost, and* ad spend — using €281.74 contribution/booking. Profitable in every scenario; break-even CPC is ~€10 vs a €2–4 reality.

✅ Go-live checklist — everything needed to finish

Already done

- ✅ Campaign config built + **dry-run validated** against the live API
- ✅ Ad extensions built into the tooling + config
- ✅ Conversion tracking live (server-side offline import, net ex-VAT value)
- ✅ Competitor recon + keyword research complete

Before you flip it on (your checks)

- ☐ **Landing page loads** at `offcourseamsterdam.com/cruises/off-beaten-path-hidden-gems-canal-cruise` — Google disapproves ads whose page 404s. Open it and confirm.
- ☐ **Billing active** on the Off Course Canal Cruises account — a campaign cannot serve without a valid payment method. Check Billing in Google Ads.
- ☐ **Conversion tracking confirmed firing** — do a test booking (or check recent `google_ads_conversions` rows) so Smart Bidding has signal from day one.

Launch sequence

- ☐ Run the `create --live` command above → creates the campaign **PAUSED**, linked to the listing, URL auto-set
- ☐ Review in the Google Ads UI: ad preview, extensions showing, keywords, geo + language, €25 budget
- ☐ **Enable** the campaign yourself (you, not me — your call to start spending)
- ☐ Write the **2-week diagnostic checkpoint** on your calendar (below)

The 2-week checkpoint (decide the rule now)

- Clicks coming, **0 bookings** + tracking confirmed → landing-page/offer problem; pause & fix, don't keep feeding
 - **Barely any clicks** → bids too low / too narrow; small tweak
 - **1–3+ bookings** → it works; scale budget, then turn on AI Max
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Open decisions for you

1. **Budget: €25/day?** Your margins (€280 contribution/booking) justify more, but €25 is the safe "prove paid converts" start. Could front-load €30 in week one for faster signal.
2. **Bidding: Maximize Conversions** (optimizes to bookings) vs **Maximize Clicks + max CPC** (cheaper pure-validation). Config uses Maximize Conversions.

Non-blocking follow-ups (after launch)

- **API token access** — application is filled and waiting on your submit; once approved, `gads research` pulls keyword data straight to the terminal.
- **Add drinks margin to conversion value** — currently Smart Bidding sees the base booking only, so it slightly under-values clicks by ~€30/booking.
- **Auction Insights** — once live, check weekly to see your position vs Bow's Journeys & Private Canal Cruises (your closest rivals).
- **Performance Max (Google Maps)** — biggest untapped surface; needs assets + conversion history. Phase 2.
- **Dutch + occasions campaigns** — Dutch company-outings, and occasion ads (proposals/birthdays) which competitors prove are in demand.